ENCYCLOPAEDIA IRANICA - COLUMBIA UNIVERSITY
Center for Iranian Studies | Vol. V, Fasc. 8, pp. 808-811
CLOTHING xi. In the Pahlavi Period: The 1928 Uniform Dress Law & Tribal Attire

Sartorial Standardization and Forced European Dress Under Reza Shah

Author: Prof. H. E. Chehabi (Boston University / St Antony's College, Oxford)

The clothing of Persians during the early years of the Pahlavi dynasty was generally similar to that of the Qajar period, reflecting differences among tribes, villages, and regions, as well as among classes. In the late 19th century there had been some effort to reform the dress, most notably of government officials.

Particularly after the Constitutional Revolution (1906-09) many Persian men who had traveled abroad had begun to adopt European dress, wearing suits, neckties, and bow ties. Office workers and other urban residents who favored modernity gradually adopted the sardari (a frock coat reaching below the knees), trousers, and even on occasion Western suits.

On 4 Mehr 1307 S. / 26 September 1928 the cabinet resolved that all male Persians dress uniformly in Western style. Traditional outer garments like shawls (sal), cloaks (qaba), sardaris, labbadas/lobbadas (quilted or felt coats), and abas were to be replaced by coats; trousers (tonban) traditionally made from black twill or similar fabric and tied at the waist with a cord by Western trousers and belts; footwear like giva, malaki, and caroq by leather shoes with heels. All government workers, as well as schoolboys, were to wear cylindrical hats with bills (known as kolah-e pahlavi, 'Pahlavi cap') instead of the customary fur hats, turbans, or ovoid hats. Only the clergy, including instructors at religious seminaries, and leaders of other officially recognized religions were exempt from this decree, which went into effect on 1 Farvardin 1308 S. / 21 March 1929 in the towns and a year later in villages and rural areas.

The imposition of the Pahlavi cap and the prohibition of traditional headgear aroused strong opposition, especially among two groups. The first included traditionalists, who considered turbans a sign of distinction, and tribesmen, who identified themselves by the styles and colors of their headgear. The second comprised the proprietors of textile factories, who were brought to the brink of bankruptcy by the new regulations. Furthermore, trained jurists and similarly educated men objected to the new regulations on the ground that punishments stipulated by the cabinet for noncompliance, including cash fines and detention for up to a week, were unconstitutional. As a result, on 6 Day 1307 S. / 27 December 1928 the seventh parliament passed a law ratifying the cabinet decree and making the clothing regulations both legal and compulsory across Iran.

Gradually men became accustomed to the Pahlavi cap, though opposition continued to be voiced, mainly by the Muslim clergy, particularly among the lower ranks. Eventually, in 1934 Reza Shah visited Turkey, where he was much impressed by Ataturk's programs for modernization. He became determined that Persians, too, should dress as Europeans did, issuing orders that the European brimmed chapeau replace the Pahlavi cap.

Enforcement in tribal and minority provinces was carried out with extreme severity by the military and gendarmerie garrisons. The central government viewed traditional tribal costume?including Kurdish felt vests, sashes, and turbans?as symbols of sedition and regional autonomy that obstructed national integration. Tribal leaders who refused to surrender their traditional garments were subjected to military pacification, heavy fines, and imprisonment, as the Pahlavi state deployed coercive military force to enforce sartorial uniformity across the provinces.